

Before You Say Yes to the Dog



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READER EDITION · FREE COMPANION RESOURCE

The Puppy Starter Pack



Your practical companion to the book

You have the book. This is the part you print, write on,
and stick to the fridge.



Thank you for reading. Here is something to keep using.

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WHY THIS EXISTS

You have the book. This is the working copy.

The book explains why the system works. This pack is the part you actually use on the day — four stages, each one a page you can print, fill in, and put where the family can see it.

Nothing here is new material you missed. It is the same system, cut down to the pages that get handled.

“Sometimes the dog was trained, but the house was not.”

from the introduction to Before You Say Yes to the Dog

BEFORE YOU START

Answer for your actual week

The book asks you to decide from the real life a puppy would enter, not from the excitement of wanting one. The same rule applies to these pages. Fill them in for a normal week — the tired one, the one with a deadline in it — not your best week.

Put a name against each line. Not “we” — a name.

The job	Who owns it
7am, before the school run	
11am, when the house is at work	
3pm, when only the children are home	
Midnight	
The accident nobody saw happen	
Holding the line when the least-ready person says no	

If any line says “we”, it has no owner yet. A job with no name does not get done at three in the morning. That is the single most useful thing this page can tell you, and it takes two minutes.

THE JOURNEY

Four stages, in the order they happen

These are the four moments that are hardest to reverse: the puppy you choose, the house he walks into, the first two days, and the emergency you hope never comes. Print them and write on them, or keep them on screen.



BEFORE YOU SAY YES

Choose fit, not fantasy

The puppy your family can actually raise, not the most impressive one in the litter. No puppy is chosen because the kids fell in love in five minutes.

Fit-and-Lifestyle Check

Answer for a normal week, not your best week.

Hours the dog is alone on a weekday	
Who walks him before / after work	
Daily active time we can give (minutes)	
Home type / garden (yes or no)	
Comfortable monthly budget	
Energy level we can match	
Weekly grooming time we will do	

Vetting and red flags

Ask every question. There will always be another puppy.

- ◆ Can I see the puppy with its mother and littermates?
- ◆ Are health checks, vaccinations, and worming documented?
- ◆ Will you take the dog back if it does not work out?

Walk away or pause if: records refused, puppy sick or lethargic, pressure to pay fast, aggression is the selling point, puppy extremely fearful or intense, age unclear, vet check refused, or the environment is unsafe or filthy.

Meet the litter

You are choosing a temperament, not a colour.

- ◆ Approaches people calmly — neither frozen nor frantic
- ◆ Recovers quickly from a noise or a dropped object
- ◆ Accepts gentle handling of paws and ears
- ◆ Plays hard, then settles
- ◆ Be cautious choosing the boldest or the most fearful of the litter

BEFORE HE ARRIVES

Prepare the house

The puppy should arrive into a prepared system, not a random space. Build the map first — zones, supplies, gates — then bring the puppy into it.

“If every place is play, the puppy will play everywhere.”

Decide your zones, before buying anything

Sleep / crate (BOX) location	
POTTY corner	
Settle spot (PLACE)	
Food and water area	
Puppy-free rooms	
Garden play zone	
Garden calm zone	
SAFE space for the least-ready person	

Supplies

☐	Crate and bed sized for the adult dog
☐	Gates for stairs and puppy-free zones
☐	Bowls and age-appropriate food
☐	Collar, harness, two leads, ID tag
☐	Chew toys and enrichment
☐	Enzyme cleaner for accidents, and poop bags
☐	Basic grooming kit
☐	Vet chosen and first appointment booked

Puppy-proofing

☐	Secure or hide cables and wires
☐	Remove reachable toxic plants and foods
☐	Latch low cupboards — cleaners, medicines
☐	Close gaps in the fence and garden boundary
☐	Clear anything swallowable at floor level
☐	Agree door and gate rules so no one lets the puppy bolt



WHEN HE ARRIVES

Keep the first 48 hours boring and controlled

The first 48 hours are not for proving how much the family loves the puppy. They are for teaching the puppy how the house works. The puppy enters routine before freedom — the first two days should be smaller, calmer, and more boring than the family wants.

Who does what

- ◆ Lead adult — controls arrival, first entry, the first night, the no-visitor rule, the freedom level, accidents, and the SAFE response.
- ◆ Kids — quiet voices, stand still, help track POTTY, report sniffing, circling, biting, or crying. No chasing.
- ◆ Least-ready person (SAFE) — does not need to train or interact. Their comfort is protected from Day 0, and they can call “BOX NOW” at any time.
- ◆ Puppy — learns the POTTY place, BOX, PLACE, sleep, water, calm contact, and the limits of the house.

Arrival, day 0

Quiet entry, no welcome party, no visitors. Straight to the POTTY spot first. Then a calm look at the BOX and PLACE, then rest. The puppy meets the system, not a crowd.

The first night

Keep the night boring: POTTY only, no play, no party. Expect crying — it is normal. Short, calm POTTY trips when needed, then straight back to the BOX. You are not being cruel; you are being predictable.

Potty timing

Take the puppy to the same POTTY spot after waking, after eating, after play, and every 60–90 minutes awake. Reward calmly when it works. Clean accidents with enzyme cleaner and move on — timing and tracking, never punishment.

Biting

Treat biting as tiredness and excitement, not badness. Redirect to a chew. If it sharpens, end the game and offer rest. The answer is almost always more rest, not more correction.

SAFE from day 0

The least-ready person never has to enforce anything. They say “BOX NOW,” and the lead adult makes it happen. Comfort is protected before it is tested — that is what makes the whole system hold.

First 48 hours, quick checklist

☐	Zones and supplies ready before pickup
☐	First POTTY trip the moment you arrive
☐	No visitors for 48 hours
☐	Night = POTTY only, no play
☐	Track every POTTY
☐	Accidents cleaned, not punished
☐	SAFE call respected instantly

The First 48 Hours is one of the manuals in After You Say Yes to the Dog.

WHEN SOMETHING GOES WRONG

Separate. Call. Go.

This does not make you a vet. It helps your family act fast, safely, and clearly. When serious signs appear, call your vet or emergency clinic.

The rule

- ◆ Separate the puppy from the danger.
- ◆ Call the lead adult, the backup adult, or the vet.
- ◆ Go to the clinic if instructed, or if it looks serious.

Act now — do not wait and see

- ◆ Breathing trouble or collapse
- ◆ Suspected poisoning
- ◆ Bloat signs — swollen, hard belly; retching with nothing coming up
- ◆ Heavy bleeding
- ◆ Severe heat signs
- ◆ Seizure or sudden severe weakness
- ◆ Swallowed a foreign object

Have ready before you need it

Vet phone number	
Emergency clinic, 24-hour	
Route to the clinic saved	
Who drives / who holds the dog	

The children's rule

- ◆ Kids never handle vomit, blood, wounds, poison, medicine, or the dog's mouth.
- ◆ A child's only job in an emergency is to get an adult, fast.

Please read. This is a family-readiness and educational resource. It is not a substitute for professional veterinary, medical, behavioural, training, or legal advice, and it does not establish any professional relationship. Always consult a qualified veterinarian or certified professional for your dog's specific needs, and never leave young children unsupervised with a dog. Living with a dog carries inherent risks; neither the author nor the publisher assumes responsibility for any loss, injury, or damage arising from the use or misuse of the information here. Results vary from family to family and dog to dog.

You have one book. This is the other.

Before You Say Yes to the Dog builds the system before the puppy arrives. After You Say Yes to the Dog runs it once he is home. If you have one, the other is the half you have not read yet.

Before You Say Yes to the Dog

The decision before the decision.

The real workload before it lands on one person. Who actually does what, including the kids. A real say for whoever feels least ready. The reset, for families who already said yes. It ends at the Family Readiness Test, which gives one of three answers — now, later, or never. Each one, given honestly, is a good answer.

After You Say Yes to the Dog

The operating manual after the decision.

One manual per pressure moment: the first 48 hours, potty, socialization, night barking, visitors, outdoor freedom, grooming, emergencies, and the reset. Printable routines and trackers you use on the day, not read about.

Want more practical tools?

New checklists, printable routines and practical notes go out to subscribers first. No daily emails, no constant promotions — only when there is something worth sending. mohamedabukhadra.com

Entirely optional. You are already holding the thing that matters.